



Self-Reflection: Stack Overflow



Activity overview

In this activity, you'll learn how to ask the data analytics community questions about the tools and programming languages you've been using in this course. You'll examine best practices for writing questions, which can help you refine the questions you ask. Knowing where to find help and how to ask questions makes you a more efficient data analyst.

Follow the instructions to complete each step of the activity. Then answer the question at the end of the activity before going to the next course item.

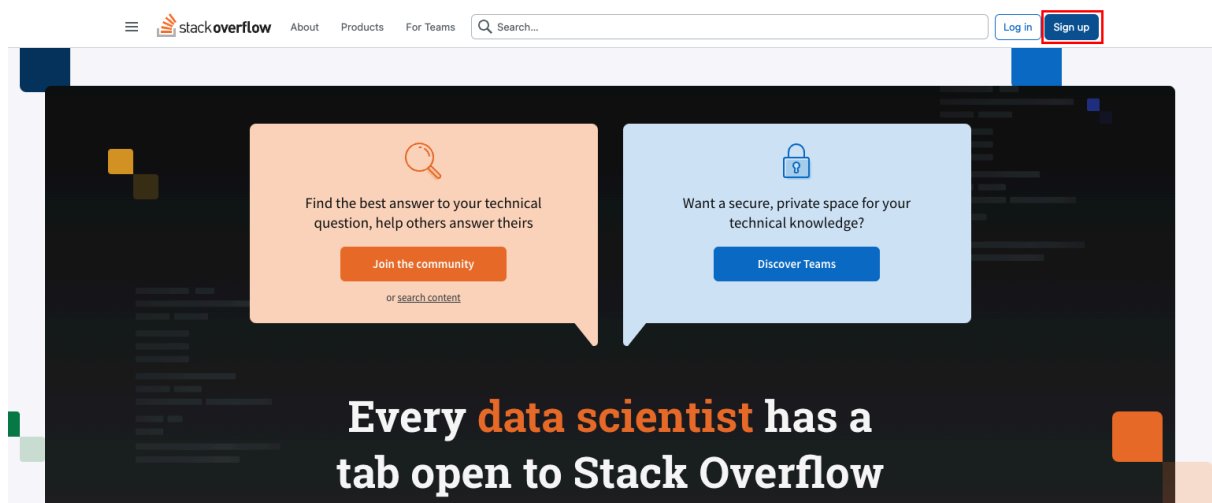
All data professionals get stuck at times and have questions. Fortunately, there are many resources available and a dynamic community to help. One such resource is Stack Overflow.

Stack Overflow is an online platform where data analysts and programmers ask code-related questions, and peers suggest answers. It provides an outlet for quick problem-solving and access to a wide-ranging knowledge base with networking and career development opportunities. You can ask questions about tools, programming languages, and much more.

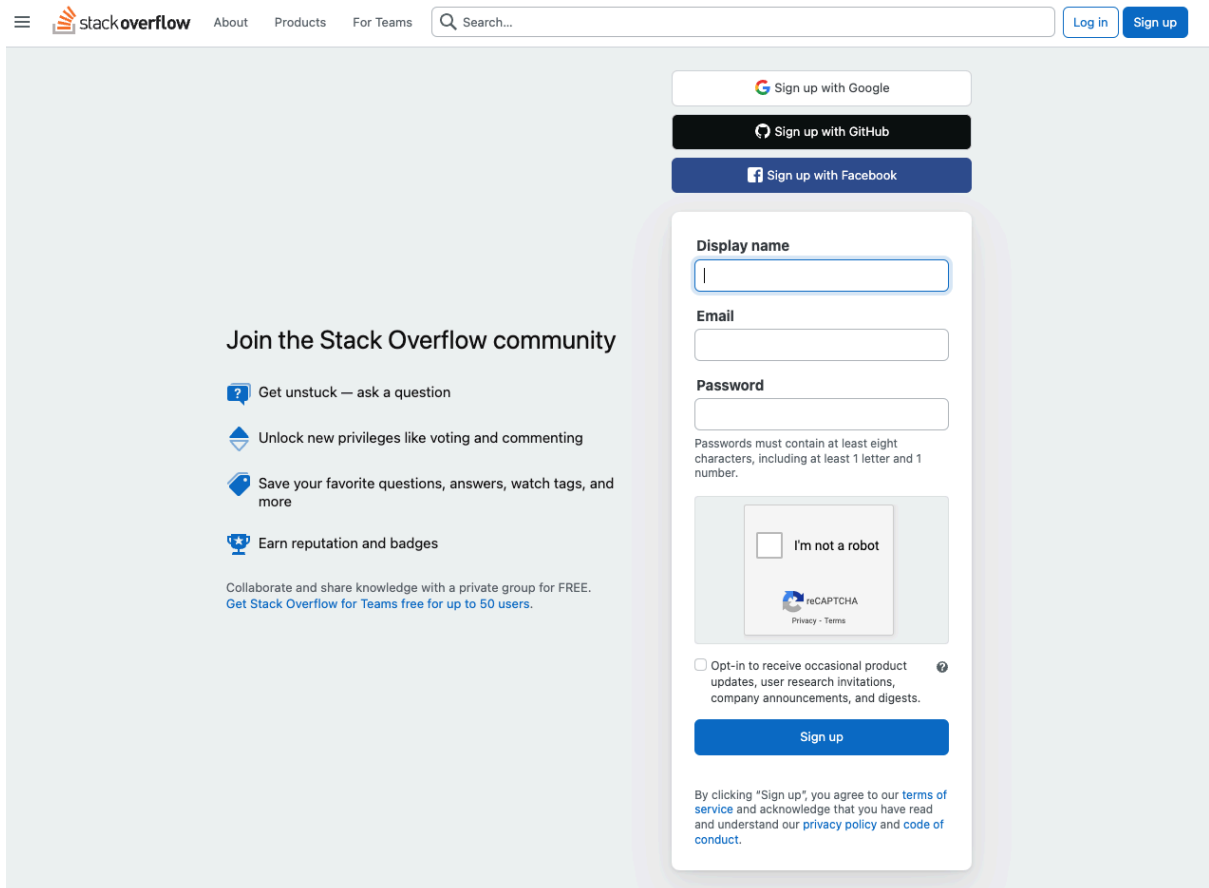
If you do not have an account, complete the following steps to sign up for Stack Overflow.

1. Navigate to the [Stack Overflow](https://stackoverflow.com) website.

2. Select the **Sign up** button.



3. Enter the display name you want to use, your email address, a password, and any other required information.



The image shows the Stack Overflow sign-up page. At the top, there is a navigation bar with the Stack Overflow logo, links for 'About', 'Products', and 'For Teams', a search bar, and 'Log in' and 'Sign up' buttons. The main content area is divided into two columns. The left column, titled 'Join the Stack Overflow community', lists four benefits: 'Get unstuck — ask a question', 'Unlock new privileges like voting and commenting', 'Save your favorite questions, answers, watch tags, and more', and 'Earn reputation and badges'. Below this, it mentions 'Collaborate and share knowledge with a private group for FREE. Get Stack Overflow for Teams free for up to 50 users.' The right column contains the sign-up form. It starts with three social login options: 'Sign up with Google', 'Sign up with GitHub', and 'Sign up with Facebook'. Below these are input fields for 'Display name', 'Email', and 'Password'. The password field has a note: 'Passwords must contain at least eight characters, including at least 1 letter and 1 number.' There is a reCAPTCHA widget with the text 'I'm not a robot'. Below the reCAPTCHA is an opt-in checkbox for receiving occasional product updates, user research invitations, company announcements, and digests. A blue 'Sign up' button is at the bottom of the form. At the very bottom, a small disclaimer states: 'By clicking "Sign up", you agree to our terms of service and acknowledge that you have read and understand our privacy policy and code of conduct.'

stackoverflow About Products For Teams Search...

Log in Sign up

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Sign up with GitHub

Sign up with Facebook

Join the Stack Overflow community

- Get unstuck — ask a question
- Unlock new privileges like voting and commenting
- Save your favorite questions, answers, watch tags, and more
- Earn reputation and badges

Collaborate and share knowledge with a private group for FREE.
Get Stack Overflow for Teams free for up to 50 users.

Display name

Email

Password

Passwords must contain at least eight characters, including at least 1 letter and 1 number.

I'm not a robot

reCAPTCHA

Privacy - Terms

☐ Opt-in to receive occasional product updates, user research invitations, company announcements, and digests.

Sign up

By clicking "Sign up", you agree to our [terms of service](#) and acknowledge that you have read and understand our [privacy policy](#) and [code of conduct](#).

Manual fields include Display name, Email, Password, and a check box that indicates you are not a robot. The Sign up button is below the check box.

4. Select **Sign up**.

5. Once you've signed up for your account, Stack Overflow will send you an email to complete your registration. Select the **Complete your registration** link.

6. You'll be prompted to upload a new photo and add any tags about technology that you use or are interested in. Once you've made any desired updates, select **Create my account**.

7. You'll be redirected to a welcome screen that provides you with an overview of the features and capabilities on Stack Overflow, as well as some how-to instruction.

Stack Overflow has several resources you can use to search for information, including a **Questions** feature, a **Tags** feature, and a **Search** bar to help you find answers to the questions you might have.

Questions

The **Questions** page provides different categories of questions for you to choose from. Some examples include Newest, Active, and Unanswered. To view all questions:

1. Select the Navigation menu (an icon of three stacked horizontal lines).
2. Select **Questions**.

Explore the types of questions listed under the different categories.



stackoverflow

Products



Search...

Home

PUBLIC



Questions

Tags

Users

Companies

COLLECTIVES



Explore Collectives

LABS



Discussions



TEAMS

Stack Overflow for Teams –
Start collaborating and sharing
organizational knowledge.



Create a free Team

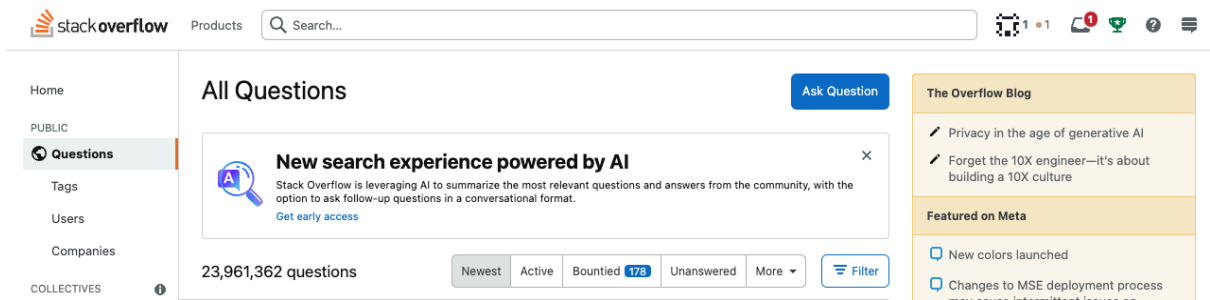
Why Teams?

Looking for your Teams?



Stack Overflow is a question and answer library for you as part of the Stack library of developer tools.

Ask



Tags

Tags are keywords or labels that can help you find questions. To view the Tags page:

1. Open the Navigation menu, then select **Tags**.

Home

PUBLIC

Questions

Tags

Users

Companies

COLLECTIVES

Explore Collectives

LABS

Discussions

TEAMS

Stack Overflow for Teams – Start collaborating and sharing organizational knowledge.

Free

Create a free Team

Why Teams?

Looking for your Teams?

Tags

A tag is a keyword or label that categorizes your question with other, similar questions. Using the right tags makes it easier for others to find and answer your question.

Show all tag synonyms

Filter by tag name

Popular

Name

New

javascript

For questions about programming in ECMAScript (JavaScript/JS) and its different dialects/implementations (except for ActionScript). Note that...

2516639 questions

281 asked today, 1640 this week

python

Python is a dynamically typed, multi-purpose programming language. It is designed to be quick to learn, understand, and use, and enforces ...

2171440 questions

505 asked today, 2735 this week

java

Java is a high-level object-oriented programming language. Use this tag when you're having problems using or understanding the language itself...

1909831 questions

204 asked today, 1127 this week

c#

C# (pronounced "see sharp") is a high-level, statically typed, multi-paradigm programming language developed by Microsoft. C# code...

1605391 questions

161 asked today, 912 this week

php

PHP is an open-source, multi-paradigm, dynamically-typed, and interpreted scripting language designed initially for server-side we...

1462151 questions

85 asked today, 531 this week

android

Android is Google's mobile operating system, used for programming or developing digital devices (Smartphones, Tablets, Automobile...

1411975 questions

131 asked today, 745 this week

html

HTML (HyperText Markup Language) is the markup language for creating web pages and other information to be displayed in a web browser...

1182635 questions

132 asked today, 747 this week

jquery

jQuery is a JavaScript library. jQuery is a popular cross-browser JavaScript library that facilitates Document Object Model (DOM)...

1034684 questions

23 asked today, 134 this week

c++

C++ is a general-purpose programming language. Use this tag for questions about utilizing C++. Do not also tag questions with [c] unle...

801137 questions

78 asked today, 539 this week

css

CSS (Cascading Style Sheets) is a representation style sheet language used for describing the look and formatting of HTML (HyperText...

799961 questions

84 asked today, 519 this week

ios

iOS is the mobile operating system running on the Apple iPhone, iPod touch, and iPad. Use this tag [ios] for questions related to programming o...

684337 questions

51 asked today, 281 this week

sql

Structured Query Language (SQL) is a language for querying databases. Questions should include code examples, table structure, sample...

666712 questions

76 asked today, 387 this week

To search for a specific tag:

1. Enter a tag name in the search bar, then press enter.
2. Select any tag to view a list of questions that have that particular tag.

Different types of tags that you can search for include:

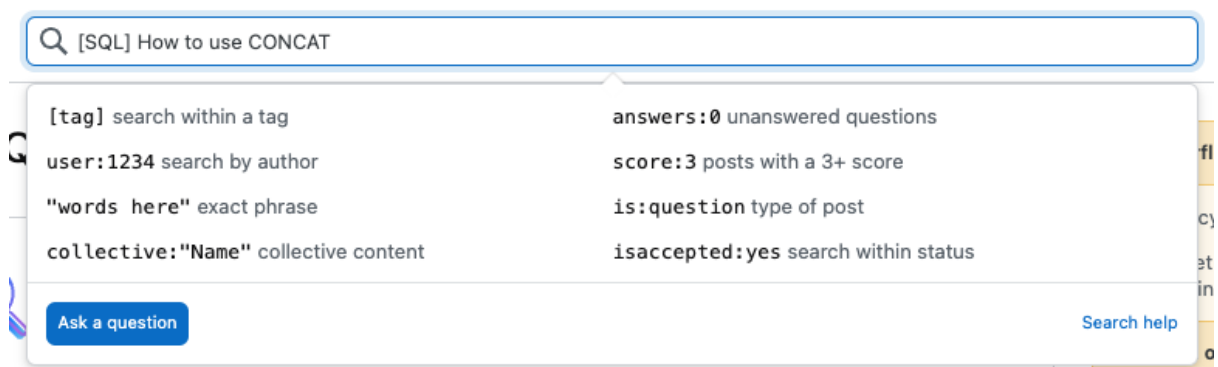
- Product lines
- Projects
- Teams
- Specific technologies

- Specific languages

You can also examine this [list of existing tags](#) for examples of which tags to use.

Search bar

Use the **Search bar** to search for keywords and questions. To view only questions with a specific tag, include the tag name in brackets within your search. For example, if you want to only find questions that have the tag “SQL,” then type **[SQL]** in the search field along with your keywords or question.



The image shows a screenshot of the Stack Overflow search interface. At the top is a search bar with a magnifying glass icon and the text "[SQL] How to use CONCAT". Below the search bar is a dropdown menu with a light gray background. The dropdown menu contains two columns of search syntax examples. The left column lists: "[tag] search within a tag", "user:1234 search by author", "\"words here\" exact phrase", and "collective:\"Name\" collective content". The right column lists: "answers:0 unanswered questions", "score:3 posts with a 3+ score", "is:question type of post", and "isaccepted:yes search within status". At the bottom left of the dropdown menu is a blue button with the text "Ask a question". At the bottom right is a blue link with the text "Search help".

[tag] search within a tag	answers:0 unanswered questions
user:1234 search by author	score:3 posts with a 3+ score
"words here" exact phrase	is:question type of post
collective:"Name" collective content	isaccepted:yes search within status

Ask a question Search help

To learn more about searching, read these [instructions on how to search](#). For a quick guide on how different syntax structures can help you search more efficiently, go to this list of [search types and search syntax](#).

The following best practices can help set you up for success when asking questions on Stack Overflow:

- Keep it specific.
- Don't use Stack Overflow to ask questions with opinion-based answers.
For example:
 - "Which SQL function can I use to add two numbers together?" is an appropriate question.
 - "Which SQL function is your favorite?" is not.
- Before asking a question, search the Stack Overflow website first—someone may have already asked it. This reduces the number of redundant questions on the site and saves you time.
- Write clear and concise questions in complete sentences. People are more likely to understand what you are asking and can give you more specific or helpful answers.

To ask your own question, follow these steps:

1. Navigate to the Stack Overflow homepage. Select **Home** from the Navigation menu or the **Stack Overflow icon**.
2. Select **Ask Question**. **Note:** If you need additional help, Stack Overflow displays some helpful tips for writing a good question and provides external links for additional resources.
3. Enter a **title** for your question. Make sure it's specific! Then, select **Next**.
4. Enter the details of the problem you're experiencing. Introduce the problem and explain the circumstances in which you encountered it. Then, select **Next**.

5. Add a description about what you tried, what you expected to happen, and what actually happened. If applicable, add a minimal, reproducible example of the code you've written so that someone can try to reproduce the issue. To insert a section of code, select **Ctrl+K** on your keyboard. Then, enter your code. When you have completed your description, select **Next**.
6. Add up to five tags that help describe your question. These tags will help to make sure your question is answered by the right people. Then, select **Next**.
7. Stack Overflow provides you with the ability to review questions that have already been asked to see if your question is a duplicate. The Stack Overflow community discourages repeat questions, so make sure to check previous questions thoroughly. If you find your question in the results listed, select that question and the hyperlink will redirect you to that question's page in a new tab. You can also select **Discard draft** at the bottom of the form on the **Ask a public question** page.
8. If you don't see your question listed, check the box to confirm that none of the posts answer your question. Then, select **Review your question**.
9. Review all the fields where you entered information about your question. If you need to make any changes, you can do so in the provided text boxes. If everything is correct, select **Post your question**.

Ask a public question



Writing a good question

You're ready to [ask a programming-related question](#) and this form will help guide you through the process. Looking to ask a non-programming question? See [the topics here](#) to find a relevant site.

Steps

- Summarize your problem in a one-line title.
- Describe your problem in more detail.
- Describe what you tried and what you expected to happen.
- Add "tags" which help surface your question to members of the community.
- Review your question and post it to the site.

Title

Be specific and imagine you're asking a question to another person.

e.g. Is there an R function for finding the index of an element in a vector?

Next

Writing a good title



Your title should summarize the problem.

You might find that you have a better idea of your title after writing out the rest of the question.

What are the details of your problem?

Introduce the problem and expand on what you put in the title. Minimum 20 characters.

Rich text editor with toolbar (bold, italic, link, etc.) and a large text area for describing the problem.

What did you try and what were you expecting?

Describe what you tried, what you expected to happen, and what actually resulted. Minimum 20 characters.

Rich text editor with toolbar (bold, italic, link, etc.) and a large text area for describing what was tried and expected.

Note: Stack Overflow is a public forum. Do not post any private information or confidential details.

1.

Question 1

Reflection

You're a junior data analyst working for a local news station and your team uses BigQuery to analyze weather trends. The station's meteorologist has tasked you with understanding the relationship between wind speed and visibility in 2023. However, you're working with the newest data and it hasn't been cleaned yet. Missing values were incorrectly entered as zeroes, and you need to change them to null values before you look for trends. The code you're using to do this is returning an error message. But don't worry! You can ask for help on Stack Overflow.

- How would you write your question?
- Which tags would you use?

Now, write 2–3 sentences (40–60 words) in response to each of these questions. Enter your response in the text box below.

I'll ask the question just like, I'm working on the newest data on the local news station and using BigQuery, but my given task is understanding the relation between wind speed and visibility in 2023. But my data is not clean, and missing values are incorrectly entered as zeros. And whatever I have written in BigQuery is returning me an error message. Please, can anyone help me to overcome this problem?

The tags are Bigquery, Missing value, weather_data, error_message, SQL

Feedback

A meaningful question would concisely summarize your problem and results. For example, “How can I replace numerical values with NULL in SQL?” You could also include a section of your code and explain that you’re struggling with getting the correct output from your query. The tags you could use include “compare,” “if-statement,” “SQL,” “subset,” “return-value,” “setvalue,” or “valueerror.”

As you learn more about SQL in this course (and as you encounter Python in the future), Stack Overflow will serve as a valuable resource and help you to succeed. Going forward, seek opportunities to ask questions and find solutions using Stack Overflow. This helpful tool allows you to further your learning and build your data analytics knowledge throughout your career.